

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

What's News

Business & Finance

- ◆ **The Trump administration** is moving its spending review beyond consulting firms to scrutinize contracts with companies providing sometimes obscure technology services to federal agencies. **B1**
- ◆ **Who might replace Warren Buffett's** insurance mastermind, Ajit Jain, when he is ready to step down has become Berkshire Hathaway's next succession story. **B1**
- ◆ **Assets in funds** promising shelter from the stock market's wild swings surged to \$56 billion so far this year, but performance has been underwhelming in many cases. **B1**
- ◆ **With Musk returning** to a more hands-on role in managing Tesla, the company's board again faces the question of how to compensate the world's richest man. **B1**
- ◆ **Rick Smith, who** co-founded and runs Axon Enterprise, the maker of Taser stun guns, tops this year's list of the highest-paid chief executives, with remuneration of \$165 million. **B5**
- ◆ **Energy-drink maker Celsius** is reaching beyond its core audience of athletes and other gym-goers with "Live.Fit.Go," which the company says is its biggest advertising campaign yet. **B3**
- ◆ **Shoe Carnival said it** would boost its investment in its Shoe Station banner in an effort to focus more on premium-brand shoes, and the company maintained its outlook for the year. **B3**
- ◆ **Retailers like Best Buy** and Target are engaging in verbal gymnastics in an attempt to communicate that they will consider raising prices without actually saying so. **B3**

World-Wide

- ◆ **Ukraine launched** audacious drone attacks on four military airports inside Russia, destroying more than 40 warplanes in the biggest blow of the war against Moscow's long-range bomber fleet. **A1**
- ◆ **Trump plans to push** lawmakers on his tax-and-spending megabill this week in an effort to overcome Republican concerns about deficit spending. **A1**
- ◆ **Six people were** injured in Boulder, Colo., in an incident the FBI is investigating as an act of terror against a group advocating for the release of hostages in Gaza. **A3**
- ◆ **Exit polls in Poland's** presidential election projected a slim victory for a conservative historian who backs the former ruling Law and Justice party and who had received a nod of support from Trump. **A7**
- ◆ **More than 20 Gazans** were killed as they made their way to a U.S.-Israeli aid-distribution center, Palestinian health authorities said, the latest violence in a chaotic rollout of a new assistance program. **A9**
- ◆ **Trump dropped Musk** as associate Jared Isaacman as the nominee to run NASA shortly before the Senate was poised to vote on confirming him in the role. **A4**
- ◆ **The DHS's controversial** "Sanctuary Jurisdictions" list disappeared from its website as the agency fights criticism from red and blue states over the criteria used to create it. **A3**
- ◆ **Died: Stanley Fischer**, 81, former Fed vice chair and governor of the Bank of Israel. **A2**

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IGOR KOZEV/TELEGRAM/REUTERS

A still image from a video showed a Ukrainian strike on the Belaya base in the Russian Irkutsk region Sunday. Four air bases were targeted with 117 drones, the Ukrainians said.

Foreigners' U.S. Travel Declines, Crimping Businesses

By CHELSEY DULANEY AND CHAO DENG

The summer vacation season has officially begun. Missing this year: the Canadians, Europeans and other foreign travelers who have flocked to America's tourist hot spots in recent years.

"There used to be thousands of people from Canada. They would give me Canadian dollars and I would change it at the bank," said Omar Tallat, 35 years old, who runs a corn dog stand near New York's Times Square. "This year, business is very bad."

About 1.9 million foreigners arrived at the U.S.'s main airports in the past four weeks, down 6% from the same period last year, according to data from U.S. Customs and Border Protection.

Airline bookings data for the summer suggest things won't be picking up soon. Flight bookings to the U.S. from Europe are down by about 12% through August. San Francisco, Washington, D.C., and Los Angeles are recording even larger declines, according to an analysis of on-line travel-agency booking data from Cirium.

Overseas travelers say they are swapping U.S. vacation plans for trips to Europe or in their own countries. Some cite the Trump administration's immigration crackdown and reports of foreign visitors being detained or deported from the U.S. Others say they want to signal their discontent with the White House's policies, echoing boycotts of American-made products by Canadians, and of Teslas in Europe.

"There's not a lot politically I can do, but what I can do is not spend my money in the U.S.," said Marc Toews, a 53-year-old Canadian long-haul truck driver. He was planning a road trip through the U.S. that would take him to North Dakota, a Chicago Cubs game and the Statue of Liberty.

"I was very excited about it. I've been talking about this trip for a few years," he said.

He said President Trump's comments about annexing Canada changed his mind. Instead,

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Trump Looks to Shore Up Support Of Republicans for Spending Bill

WASHINGTON—President Trump plans to push lawmakers on his tax-and-spending megabill this week in an effort to overcome Republican concerns about deficit spending.

By Alex Leary, Richard Rubin and Michael R. Gordon

As the White House also seeks to get trade talks with China back on track, Trump plans to have a call with Chinese leader Xi Jinping this week in hopes of easing tensions that

have risen in recent days, administration officials said.

The economic focus sets up a big week for Trump and his overall agenda, which has been mired in court and other battles. Last week, the Trump administration appealed a significant ruling striking down global tariffs. Separately, Trump accused Beijing of violating the terms of an agreement reached earlier in May.

Trump is expected to amplify calls for Republican unity around the bill and speak with Senate Majority

Leader John Thune (R., S.D.) about the next steps as lawmakers return from recess, a senior official said Sunday. But Thune, like his counterpart in the House, has a narrow majority, and a number of GOP senators have expressed concerns that could derail a July 4 target of getting the bill to Trump's desk.

Over the weekend, Trump took aim at one of the concerned lawmakers, Sen. Rand Paul (R., Ky.), who says the bill will "explode" the debt. If Paul "votes against our Great, Big,

Beautiful Bill, he is voting for, along with the Radical Left Democrats," Trump said on social media Saturday. "Rand will be playing right into the hands of the Democrats, and the GREAT people of Kentucky will never forgive him!"

Paul didn't back down, saying Sunday on CBS that "the math doesn't really add up" and that there is too much spending. Paul said he thinks

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◆ **Federal spending review looks at tech firms.....** A8

INSIDE



PERSONAL JOURNAL
A picture-perfect girls' weekend in the Hamptons has become a four-figure affair. **A12**

SPORTS

Shohei Ohtani does it all, but the injury-racked Dodgers need him to do more. **A14**

The Two-Word Greeting Driving Shoppers Nuts

* * *

'Welcome in' has spread to coffee shops, credit unions; customers aren't sure why

By JOE PINSKER

Welcome in, reader.

Not "welcome," but "welcome in." We're delighted you stopped by. But are you? Or is that phrase highly annoying to you, like it is to Natasha Chernis of Los Angeles?

The 32-year-old software developer was perplexed when a retail worker first greeted her with "welcome in."

"I just kind of stared at them because I thought they were going to finish the sen-

tence with something else," she said.

Years later, the phrase feels to Chernis like an overdone attempt at folksiness and hospitality.

Across the country, people are hearing "welcome in" at coffee shops, credit unions, yoga studios, dermatology clinics and convenience stores. The phrase has taken off in the 2020s, and customers say they are baffled by its sudden popularity. One reader wrote

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Iran-Backed Militias Use Visa, Mastercard in Scam

After an Iraqi banking loophole was closed, armed groups pivot to get U.S. dollars by using cards in a currency-exchange scheme

By DAVID S. CLOUD

Iraq was a minor market for Visa and Mastercard a couple of years ago, generating just \$50 million a month or less in cross-border transactions at the start of 2023. Then it exploded to around \$1.5 billion in April that year, a 2900% increase almost overnight.

What changed? Iraqi militia groups figured out how to squeeze dollars on an industrial scale from Visa and Mastercard's payment networks for themselves and for their allies in Iran, according to U.S. and Iraqi officials and documents reviewed by

The Wall Street Journal.

The shift into cards came after the U.S. Treasury and the Federal Reserve Bank of New York in late 2022 shut down a gaping loophole being used for fraud—international wire transactions by Iraqi banks that lacked money-laundering safeguards. Flaws in that system, created by the U.S. during the occupation of Iraq, allowed Iran and the militia groups it supports to access billions of dollars over more than a decade.

After the U.S. finally closed that spigot, militias quickly found ways to profit from

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Medicare Bets Turned Sour for UnitedHealth

By ANNA WILDE MATHEWS AND CHRISTOPHER WEAVER

On Feb. 5, top executives of UnitedHealth Group gathered in a conference center on the company's suburban Minneapolis campus. Chief Executive Officer Andrew Witty stood up in the front and offered an encouraging message: Business was good. He was optimistic about the company's prospects in the coming year.

A trio of other executives extolled the recent insurance season, when people start their new coverage, including a

large number of Medicare enrollees. They were happy with how smoothly things were going.

Two months later, those same Medicare patients would be at the center of a financial meltdown that has wiped out more than \$250 billion in market capitalization at the healthcare giant.

On April 17, Witty announced disappointing profits and cut UnitedHealth's earnings projection for the rest of 2025. Weeks later, the company withdrew its financial

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